

1 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 20 minutes

Map an imaginary island

What we are practising

Represent an imagined place using pictures and simple symbols.

What you need

Paper / Pencils or crayons

Describe the island while an adult draws.

Before you begin

Draw a large outline with room for three places.

An adult explains as needed and uses intact, age-appropriate drawing materials.

Try it together

1. Add a home, a pond and a surprising place such as a singing tree.
2. Connect the places with paths and choose a symbol for each.
3. Trace a journey while telling what happens at each stop.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What symbol would help a visitor find your special place?

Space to explore

2 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 30 minutes

A recycled toy shelter

What we are practising

Plan, make and revise a structure for a stated purpose.

What you need

Clean small cardboard box / Scrap cardboard / Paper tape / Small soft toy / Paper / Pencil

Use folded paper walls without tape.

Before you begin

An adult removes staples and rough edges and cuts any needed doorway.

An adult handles all cutting and checks packaging for staples; no plastic bags, strings or sharp scraps.

Try it together

1. Place the toy beside the box and sketch a shelter with an entrance.
2. Build walls or a roof using cardboard and tape.
3. Test whether the toy fits and the entrance works; change one part if needed.

Talk, draw or show your idea

How will the toy enter without knocking the roof off?

Space to explore

3 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 20 minutes

Over-and-under paper weaving

What we are practising

Follow an alternating action to create a woven pattern.

What you need

Two paper colours / Scissors for adult use / Paper tape

Lay strips over a drawn grid without weaving.

Before you begin

An adult prepares four broad parallel strips taped at one end and four loose strips.

An adult cuts all broad strips; the child weaves away from the scissors.

Try it together

1. Slide one loose strip over the first fixed strip, under the second, over the third and under the fourth.
2. Weave the next strip in the opposite order.
3. Repeat with remaining strips and gently slide the rows together.

Talk, draw or show your idea

What changes at the start of the second row?

Space to explore

4 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 15 minutes

Draw a tiny music score

What we are practising

Use a shared symbol system to communicate a creative sequence.

What you need

Paper / Pencil

Use silent hand movements instead of sounds.

Before you begin

Agree circle means clap, line means knee tap and empty box means silence.

Keep sounds gentle and movements comfortable; avoid any sound that feels unpleasant.

Try it together

1. Draw four equal boxes and put a symbol in each, leaving one empty.
2. Point steadily to each box while performing its sound or pause.
3. Exchange the score with a partner, then change one symbol and compare.

Talk, draw or show your idea

How can we show a pause without a word?

Space to explore

5 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 20 minutes

One subject, three styles

What we are practising

Explore how different visual choices change an image.

What you need

Paper / Crayons or pencils

Describe three imagined versions while an adult sketches.

Before you begin

Divide a page into three spaces and choose a tree as the starter subject.

An adult explains as needed and uses intact, age-appropriate drawing materials.

Try it together

1. Draw a tree in the first space using mostly straight lines.
2. Draw it again using mostly curves, then a third time using dots.
3. Give each version a title and describe which marks changed its mood.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Which version feels calm or lively to you, and why?

Space to explore

6 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A vehicle for puddle town

What we are practising

Connect a fictional vehicle feature to the cargo it must protect.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Sketch a delivery vehicle and label its dry space.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Design an imaginary delivery vehicle for a town full of puddles. How will its parcels stay dry?

Space to explore

7 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A message in three pictures

What we are practising

Sequence three pictures to communicate a short instruction.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Create three action pictures and let a partner interpret them.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Make a three-picture message that tells a pretend visitor: come in, put down your book, and sit. Which pictures would help?

Space to explore

8 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

The painter with a long handle

What we are practising

Adapt an imaginary tool to a particular reach problem.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw a tool that solves the pretend painter's reach problem.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A story painter cannot reach the top of a very tall pretend canvas. What imaginary tool could help without climbing?

Space to explore

9 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

The same cup from above

What we are practising

Compare how one familiar object looks from different viewpoints.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw two views of one invented cup.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Draw a pretend cup from the side and from above. Which features would still help someone recognise it?

Space to explore

10 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A picture revealed by a fold

What we are practising

Use a paper fold to control when a picture detail is revealed.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Fold paper once and design a bud outside with a surprise inside.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A folded drawing shows only a small closed bud. What could appear when you open the paper?

Space to explore

11 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A museum of impossible objects

What we are practising

Explain a fictional object through its invented function.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw an impossible museum object and give it an explanatory label.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Invent an object for a pretend museum: a spoon that collects dreams. What picture and short label would explain it?

Space to explore

12 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

Acting with an absent prop

What we are practising

Suggest an absent object's weight and use through mime.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw the absent book, then mime opening it while seated.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

How could an actor show opening a heavy imaginary book without holding a real book?

Space to explore

13 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A face made without circles

What we are practising

Invent recognisable facial features within a shape constraint.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw an invented face with straight lines and describe its character.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Can you create a friendly imaginary face using only straight lines? Which features will make its expression clear?

Space to explore

14 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A celebration for the smallest guest

What we are practising

Consider how a scene appears from a small character's viewpoint.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw a decoration placed for a tiny fictional guest.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Design a pretend party decoration that a tiny mouse guest can see close to the floor. What would you change?

Space to explore

15 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A tool for a floating library

What we are practising

Balance protection and access in a fictional storage design.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Sketch a book-storage idea for an imaginary cloud library.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

A story library floats on clouds. How could its books stay together when a breeze arrives?

Space to explore

16 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

Two animals, one invention

What we are practising

Reason about a challenge created by combining two animal features.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Combine two animal features and explain a fictional challenge.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Invent a story animal with a turtle's shell and a bird's wings. What new challenge would your creature have?

Space to explore

17 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

The important empty space

What we are practising

Use empty space as a purposeful part of a picture.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Reserve a blank path and draw a garden around it.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Draw a busy garden but leave one clear empty path through it. How does the blank space help the picture?

Space to explore

18 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

One object, two pretend uses

What we are practising

Use context to give one pictured object two pretend meanings.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw the same long shape in two different pretend scenes.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

In a pretend story, how could the same scarf picture become both a river and a dragon?

Space to explore

19 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A tune that asks a question

What we are practising

Explore how a short sound sequence can invite a response.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw marks for a sound question and perform its reply gently.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Create a gentle three-sound phrase that feels unfinished, then a reply that feels finished to you. What changes?

Space to explore

20 / 20 | Ages 5-6 | 10 minutes

A recipe for a silly story

What we are practising

Connect three unrelated objects through an invented story.

What you need

Paper / Large crayons

Describe or gesture your idea while a partner draws or writes.

Before you begin

Read the question aloud together. Use imagined people and places.

A grown-up reads and joins in; use intact drawing tools and let the child pause or pass.

Try it together

1. Draw the three story ingredients and connect them with one event.
2. Show or say your first answer before reading the example.
3. Explain one choice, then try the extra challenge if you wish.

Talk, draw or show your idea

Combine a moon, a lost shoe and a helpful tree in one tiny story. What connects all three?

Space to explore

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

1. Map an imaginary island

A little hint

Use a simple repeated mark, such as a music note for the singing tree.

Answer / what to notice

Any connected, explainable map works; invented geography is welcome.

A map uses selected symbols to represent places without drawing every detail.

Make it easier

Draw two places and one path.

Take it further

Add a small key explaining three symbols.

Another day, away from the screen

Let another person choose a route and tell the adventure.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

2. A recycled toy shelter

A little hint

Compare the entrance with the toy's widest part.

Answer / what to notice

A shelter succeeds if the toy fits and can enter; appearance can vary.

Testing against a purpose helps us decide what to improve.

Make it easier

Use an open-sided box and add a roof only.

Take it further

Add a second room with a connecting entrance.

Another day, away from the screen

Invent a visitor and a story set in the shelter.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

3. Over-and-under paper weaving

A little hint

If the first row starts over, the next starts under.

Answer / what to notice

Adjacent rows alternate their starting position to interlock the strips.

Passing strips above and below each other holds a woven arrangement together.

Make it easier

Use two fixed strips and one loose strip.

Take it further

Choose colours to create an additional repeating pattern.

Another day, away from the screen

Look closely at the woven threads of a towel.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

4. Draw a tiny music score

A little hint

Keep an empty box the same length as a sounding box.

Answer / what to notice

Any sequence that follows the agreed key works; an empty box represents one beat of silence.

Symbols let another person recreate our chosen pattern.

Make it easier

Use two boxes and one sound type.

Take it further

Compose eight boxes with two planned pauses.

Another day, away from the screen

Make a gentle soundtrack for a four-part story.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

5. One subject, three styles

A little hint

There is no required mood; point to a mark that supports your idea.

Answer / what to notice

All three interpretations are valid; the discussion should connect choices with effects.

Changing marks can alter a picture while keeping its subject recognisable.

Make it easier

Try only two styles.

Take it further

Repeat using different sizes or colours and compare.

Another day, away from the screen

Display the three versions as a small family exhibition.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

6. A vehicle for puddle town

A little hint

Show the water and the protected parcel space.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: A covered parcel box sits above the wheels, with a door that closes. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A design detail is useful when it responds to the problem given.

Make it easier

Add a cover to an adult's vehicle drawing.

Take it further

Show how parcels enter without the cover disappearing.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

7. A message in three pictures

A little hint

Give each action its own picture.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: I draw an open doorway, a book on a table and a person on a chair. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Sequenced pictures can represent actions, but a reader may need clarification.

Make it easier

Represent one action with one picture.

Take it further

Change one picture after hearing a different interpretation.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

8. The painter with a long handle

A little hint

Think about the handle rather than making the painter taller.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: A brush with a long bendable handle could reach the upper corner. Other reasoned ideas can work.

An invented tool can extend what a character can reach in a story.

Make it easier

Choose a short or long handle and explain.

Take it further

Show how the painter changes colours with the tool.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

9. The same cup from above

A little hint

Imagine looking down into the opening.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: The handle appears in both, while the round opening is clearer from above. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A different viewpoint changes visible shapes without changing the object.

Make it easier

Compare two views drawn by an adult.

Take it further

Add a front view and keep the same decoration.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

10. A picture revealed by a fold

A little hint

Decide what belongs outside and what stays hidden.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: A large flower and visiting butterfly could be hidden inside the fold. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A fold can control which part of a picture the viewer sees first.

Make it easier

An adult folds; choose the hidden picture.

Take it further

Make the outside image give a small clue to the inside.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

11. A museum of impossible objects

A little hint

Show what the spoon holds in your imaginary world.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: I draw stars in the spoon and label it “Dream scoop: collects bedtime stories.” Other reasoned ideas can work.

An illustration and label can work together to explain an invented purpose.

Make it easier

Name the object while an adult writes.

Take it further

Add a rule explaining when the object works.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

12. Acting with an absent prop

A little hint

Keep the imaginary book the same size throughout.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: Slow wide hand movements could show the size, then a careful page turn. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Consistent gestures help an audience imagine an absent object.

Make it easier

Copy one page-turning gesture.

Take it further

Show a tiny book next and explain the changed gestures.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

13. A face made without circles

A little hint

Corners and zigzags can replace curved marks.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: I use angled eyes and an upward V-shaped mouth, then explain the greeting it gives. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A constraint encourages alternative ways to represent familiar features.

Make it easier

An adult draws the outline; add two features.

Take it further

Change only the mouth and describe a different interpretation.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

14. A celebration for the smallest guest

A little hint

Show the mouse beside the decoration.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: I draw a row of large flower pictures low on the wall, near the mouse's eye level. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Considering the viewer's position can change where a design belongs.

Make it easier

Choose between a high and low decoration.

Take it further

Add a decoration visible to both a mouse and a giraffe.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

15. A tool for a floating library

A little hint

Think about both keeping books in and taking one out.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: Shelves with closing fronts could keep the books inside until someone chooses one. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A protective feature should still allow the intended everyday use.

Make it easier

Add a closing front to a drawn shelf.

Take it further

Show a visitor finding a particular book.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

16. Two animals, one invention

A little hint

Explain a difficulty as well as a useful feature.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: Its shell may make flying tricky, so I invent wide strong wings and a slow landing. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Combining features invites reasoning about how the parts might work together in fiction.

Make it easier

An adult sketches a turtle and a bird; choose one feature from each.

Take it further

Invent a habitat that suits the new creature.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

17. The important empty space

A little hint

Choose the path before filling the garden.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: The blank path separates the plants and shows where a visitor might walk. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Unmarked space can be an intentional part of a composition.

Make it easier

An adult marks the path's edges.

Take it further

Make the path lead the eye to one special feature.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

18. One object, two pretend uses

A little hint

Keep the long shape; change its context.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: Blue waves around it suggest a river; a drawn head and tail suggest a dragon. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Changing the surrounding details can change how a viewer interprets a shape.

Make it easier

Choose one of the two uses to draw.

Take it further

Invent a third use with a different clue.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

19. A tune that asks a question

A little hint

Use humming, gentle taps or spoken sound names.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: I end the first phrase with a pause and answer it with three settled taps. Other reasoned ideas can work.

Listeners may hear completion differently; describing your choice makes the intention clear.

Make it easier

Use a two-sound call and one-sound reply.

Take it further

Ask a listener how they heard the two endings.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.

For the grown-up

Use these prompts when useful. Open-ended activities can have many good answers. Let your child explain their thinking.

20. A recipe for a silly story

A little hint

Give each chosen object a job in the story.

Answer / what to notice

Example answer: The moon lights the shoe caught in a branch, and the tree bends to return it. Other reasoned ideas can work.

A connection gives separate imaginative ingredients a shared purpose.

Make it easier

Connect only the shoe and tree first.

Take it further

Change the moon's role without removing it.

Another day, away from the screen

Keep your drawing and ask a partner to invent a different solution to the same question.